

STARTER KIT

AI Design Harness

Write design decisions down once, so people and AI agents build from the same place.

github.com/sadakoa/ai-design-harness

WHY

Why it exists

Design knowledge lives in designers' heads. This writes it down where agents can use it too.

Today

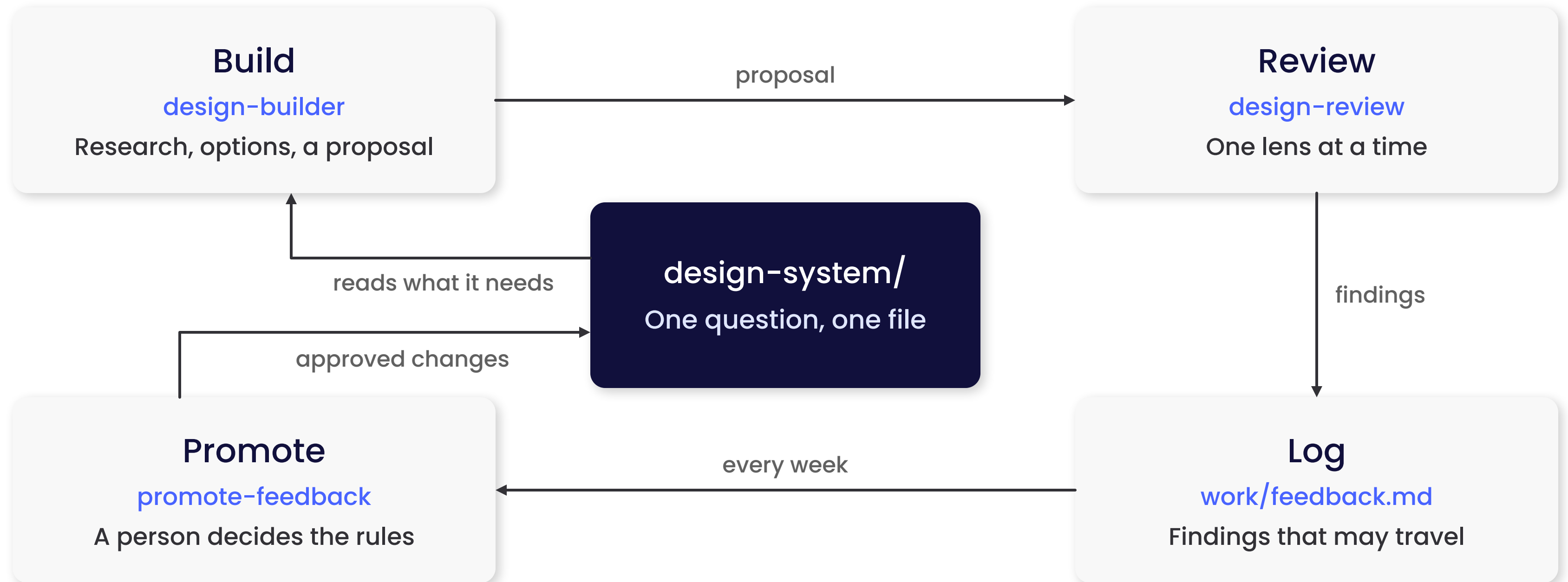
- ✗ One long doc mixes rules, values and one-off decisions
- ✗ Agents read all of it, every time
- ✗ Review findings stay buried in comments

With the harness

- ✓ One question, one file
- ✓ Agents read only what the task needs
- ✓ Findings flow back into the rules

HOW IT FLOWS

The loop



IDEA 1

One question, one file

INDEX.md — the map: which file answers what, and what to read for each task

What is this value?
tokens/tokens.json

Which CSS variables can I use?
tokens/tokens.css (generated)

What do we choose, and why?
foundations/principles.md

What must we never do?
foundations/rules.md

How do we write UI text?
foundations/writing.md

Which component should I use?
components/GUIDE.md

How does this component behave?
components/<name>.md

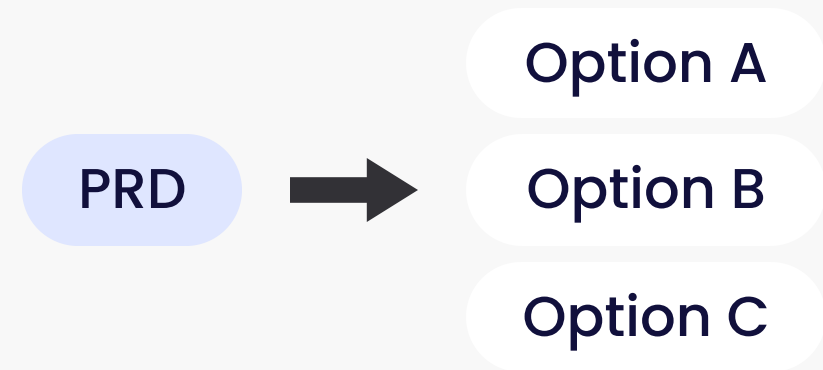
How do components make a screen?
patterns/GUIDE.md

What do approved screens look like?
screens/

Why did we decide this?
decisions.md

Build wide, review narrow

Build: open up

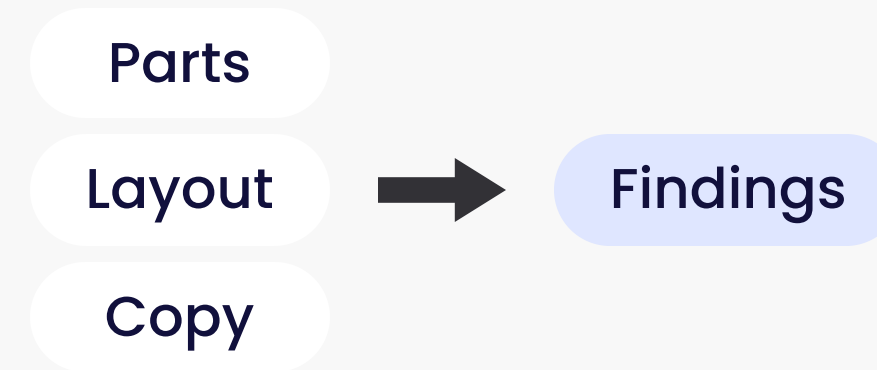


READS

principles · rules · writing
patterns · tokens.css · screens

When needed: components

Review: narrow down



READS, ONE LENS AT A TIME

Parts: principles, rules, components, tokens.css

Layout: principles, rules, patterns

Copy: rules, writing

IDEA 2

Reading by task

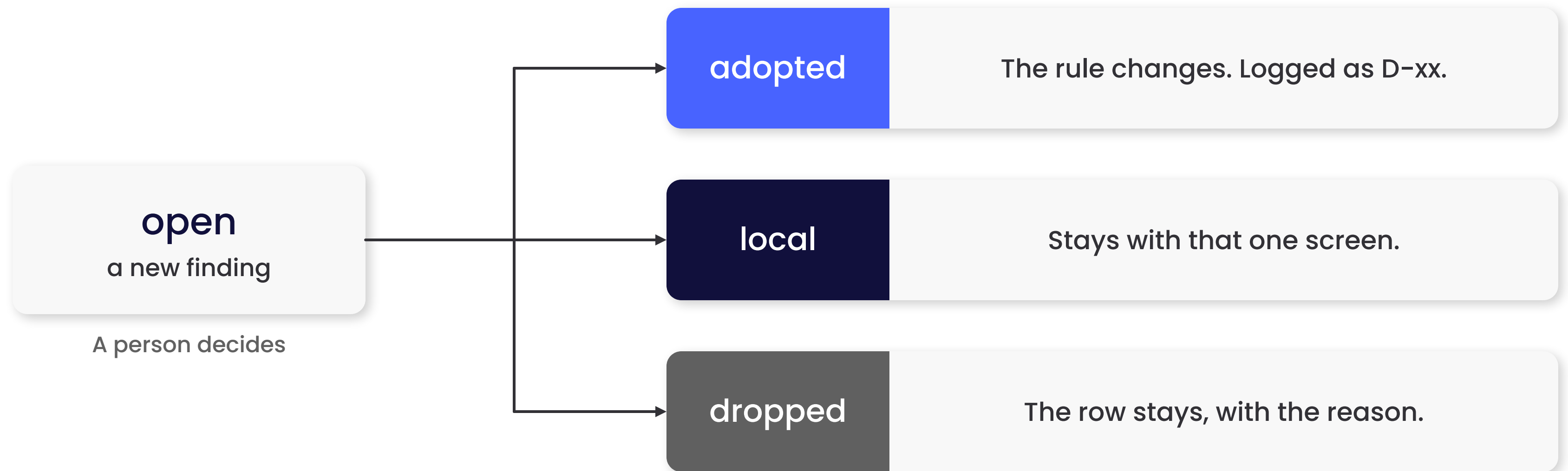
● always · ○ when it's relevant · blank means skip · taken from INDEX.md

File	Build	Parts	Layout	Copy	Promote
INDEX.md	●	●	●	●	●
tokens/tokens.css	●	●	○		
tokens/tokens.json					○
foundations/principles.md	●	●	●	○	●
foundations/rules.md	●	●	●	●	●
foundations/writing.md	●			●	○
components/GUIDE.md	○	●			○
components/<name>.md	○	○			○
patterns/GUIDE.md	●		●		○
screens/README.md	●		○		
decisions.md					●

IDEA 3

Feed reviews back

Promote a finding when it came up on two or more screens, or twice — and one file clearly owns it.



IN PRACTICE

design-builder, step by step

01

Read

Copy the PRD into the
feature folder

02

Frame

Whose job gets better,
and how

03

Ask

Only what changes the
design

04

Research

Approved screens first,
then others

05

Explore

About three working
options

06

Recommend

Pick one, tie it to a
principle

07

Write up

Everything on one HTML
page

08

Review

Run design-review, then
hand over

What the check catches

`npm run check` runs on your machine and on every pull request.

Index drift

A file not in INDEX.md, or a mismatched question

Stale tokens

tokens.css not rebuilt after tokens.json changed

Hard-coded colors

Raw colors in screens and options (R-01)

Unknown variables

CSS variables that aren't in tokens.css

Duplicate IDs

Two P-, R-, D- or FB- entries with one number

Loose ends

Adopted feedback with no decision behind it

IN PRACTICE

Running it as a team

First months

Only maintainers change the design system. Decide in batches.

Then

Designers open PRs too. Start with copy and guidelines.

Every week

Someone runs promote-feedback. A person decides.

Approvals

With two or more people, require a Code Owner's review.

NOT FOR

Screens with no precedent. Keep designers on the moments that change the experience.

START

Getting started

- 1 Replace everything marked (example)
- 2 Write component specs as you need them
- 3 Put your own handles in CODEOWNERS
- 4 Run `npm run tokens`, then `npm run check`

What's inside	
design-system/	The source of truth
work/features/	Explorations and proposals
work/feedback.md	The feedback log
.claude/skills/	The three skills
scripts/	check and build-tokens